attention to economic history and too little to imperial history.'[70] One caveat, however, is the issue of military expenditure, although even here the picture is complex.[71] The correlation between the international standing of a country and the numerical strength of its military is difficult to define and not always obvious. For example, in Persia the withdrawal of British troops in the years after the First World War was seen by some as a sign of Britain's weakness. Yet there had always been a level of resentment among the Persian population at the stationing of foreign troops in their country – thus, removal of these soldiers could be said to have improved Britain's standing in the eyes of some. When it came to India's military capabilities after 1918, while it was important that Delhi could command a strong enough force to defeat Afghanistan in the 1919 conflict, the size of the army was of little relevance to the Indian government's ability to deal effectively with Gandhi. Indeed, after the First World War overt shows of military strength within India often harmed Britain's position more than it helped, as the Amritsar Massacre demonstrated.[72] When it comes to the notion of 'power' (or 'the ability to influence others') economic capability is thus but one part of its composition. Perception plays a large role. Britain may have been economically and militarily weakened by the First World War, but as long as other nations believed it to be strong, that was the main thing.

That prestige was a crucial asset to the empire was acknowledged by practically all those involved in Britain's foreign affairs: as Harold Nicolson put it: 'What credit is to a large firm of bankers, prestige is to the administration of Empire.'[73] The intangible forces of authority and reputation were believed by British contemporaries to be particularly important to its position within Asia and the Middle and Far East. Lord Minto, Viceroy of India from 1905 to 1910, articulated what many within the government thought when he said that 'We must remember the huge influence of British prestige... it has solid value in the East'.[74] Despite what some writers have said, nobody in the British government – either in London or Delhi or elsewhere – displayed any disillusionment with the empire. In the post-war years, rather than seeing a beleaguered second-rate world power, many believed just the opposite: the proven 'greatness' of the British Empire.[75] Even some foreign observers believed that the empire was still a force to be reckoned with, as one German noted in 1920: